

Building the Grid

The 12-Point System

A grid you only talked about last class is still just an idea. Tonight it becomes something your file actually holds you to.

Two Grids, Aligned

A baseline grid alone. A modular grid alone. Combined, they're the discipline that makes a portfolio look considered instead of assembled.



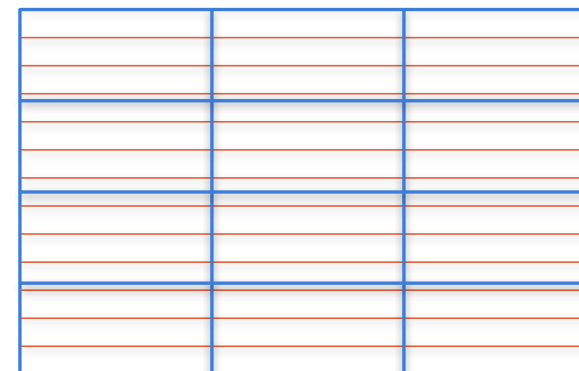
Baseline Grid

Fine ruled lines every
12 points. Text locks here.



Modular Grid

The coarse field of
columns and rows. Blocks live here.



Both, Combined

One file, one unit,
governing both.

Choose Your Leading First

A column grid can wing it, the leading can flex. A modular grid can't: the leading is the building block every other measurement is built from, so it has to be decided before anything else, not adjusted after the fact.

THE RULE

Pick a round, easily divisible number. 10 and 12 both work.

Why This Class Uses 12

Twelve divides cleanly by two, three, four, and six. It also leaves room for a 9.5–10pt body text size, the range most designers treat as optimal for running text. Ten would force a different, less flexible type scale.

STEP 2

Set the Document Size

Once the leading is fixed, the page height has to be a whole multiple of it. Not close. Exact.

1

Preferences > Units & Increments: set Ruler Units to Points

2

File > New Document: Width 600pt, Height 840pt

3

Facing Pages on · 14 pages (7 spreads)

840 / 12 = 70, no remainder. That's the whole reason this page size, not some other one, is correct for a 12-point system.

New Document

Width:	600 pt
Height:	840 pt
Pages:	14
☒ Facing Pages	

OK

STEP 3

Set the Margins

Margins have to be multiples of 12 too, or the rows won't divide evenly no matter what you do later.

MARGIN	VALUE	x12
Top	36 pt	3 x 12
Bottom	48 pt	4 x 12
In/Out	36 pt	3 x 12

The trap: a margin like 40pt looks reasonable, but 40 isn't divisible by 12. Build a grid on top of that and you get 3.333 rows instead of a whole number, impossible to align.

Margins and Columns

Top:

36 pt

12 x 3

Bottom:

48 pt

12 x 4

Inside/Outside:

36 pt

OK

STEP 4

Turn On the Baseline Grid

View > Grids & Guides > Show Baseline Grid. Then fix the one setting everyone misses.

THE GOTCHA

By default the baseline grid only appears once you're zoomed to 75% or more. Zoom out and it vanishes, it isn't gone, you just can't see it.

The Fix

Preferences > Grids > View Threshold: change it to 25%, so the grid stays visible at any reasonable zoom level while you work.

Optional

Grid color: light gray reads calmer than the default blue while you're placing content.

Preferences > Grids

Start:	0 pt
Relative To:	Top Margin
Increment Every:	12 pt
View Threshold:	25%

OK

Do the Row Math

Before touching Create Guides, confirm the numbers actually fit. Three lines, no guessing.

- 1** Page height minus margins: $840 - 36 - 48 = 756$ pt of content height
- 2** Divide by the baseline increment: $756 / 12 = 63$ whole baseline lines, no remainder
- 3** 8 rows of 7 content lines each, plus 7 gutters of 1 line each: $(8 \times 7) + (7 \times 1) = 63$, exact fit

STEP 6

Create the Guides

The math already checked out, so this dialog just executes it.

1 Layout > Create Guides

2 Enter Rows, Columns, and Gutter, fit to Margins

3 Click OK, every row lands exactly on a baseline line

Create Guides

Rows:	8
Columns:	6
Gutter:	12 pt
Fit Guides to:	Margins

OK

The Whole System, One Page

Every setting from tonight, on one page, so you can see what each number is actually for.

PHASE 2
Technical Execution of the "Atomic Unit"

- 1 Document Setup**
Units: Points | Width: 600pt | Height: 840pt | 14 pages (7 spreads) | Facing Pages
- 2 Baseline Grid**
Preferences > Grids | Start: 0pt (Top Margin) | Increment: 12pt | View > Show Baseline Grid
- 3 Margins & Columns**
Layout > Margins and Columns | Top: 36pt | Bottom: 48pt | Inside/Outside: 36pt | 6 columns, 12pt gutter
- 4 Modular Grid (Rows)**
Layout > Create Guides | 8 rows, 12pt gutter | Fit Guides to: Margins | Result: 7 content lines + 1 gutter

Preferences > Grids

Start:

Relative To:

Increment Every:

OK

A

▶

Margins and Columns

Top: (12x3)

Bottom: (12x4)

Inside/Outside:

Columns: Gutter:

OK

B

▶

Layout > Create Guides

Rows:

Gutter:

Fit Guides to:

OK

C

Result: 600 x 840pt Page with Both Grids Active

Modular Grid
6 columns + 8 rows (blue)

Baseline Grid
70 lines at 12pt (orange)

Margins
36 / 48 / 36 / 36pt (dashed)

— Modular grid (6 cols + 8 rows) — Baseline grid (12pt increment)

A Note on Printing

600×840pt is the easiest version of this system to learn: every number divides cleanly, and the row math has zero remainder. It's not, however, a real sheet of paper.

IF YOU'RE ACTUALLY PRINTING YOUR PORTFOLIO

Use 612×792pt instead, true 8.5×11in Letter, the size in every printer tray. The page itself still divides cleanly by 12 ($792 / 12 = 66$), which is what this week's reading, "The Inch Was Already Twelve," walks through. Rows do not divide as cleanly as they do at 600×840: expect a small offset between some row lines and the baseline grid unless you also adjust the bottom margin. Ask if you want the exact adjusted numbers.

Everyone Else

Stick with 600×840pt. It's not wrong, it's the version built for learning the system fast, not for a specific paper tray.

Grid Checklist

Confirm every item before you consider tonight's setup finished.

- 1** **Leading chosen first: 12pt**
- 2** **Document size is a multiple of the leading: 600 × 840pt**
- 3** **Margins are multiples of 12: 36 / 48 / 36 / 36**
- 4** **Baseline grid on, view threshold set to 25% so it stays visible**
- 5** **Row math checked by hand before Create Guides: 63 lines, no remainder**
- 6** **6 columns, 8 rows, 12pt gutters, every row lands on a baseline line**

Quick Reference

Keep this open while you work.

ACTION	MAC	WINDOWS
Toggle Baseline Grid	Cmd + Opt + '	Ctrl + Alt + '
Preview Mode	W	W
Show/Hide Guides	Cmd + ;	Ctrl + ;
Snap to Guides	Shift + Cmd + ;	Shift + Ctrl + ;
Fit Spread in Window	Opt + Cmd + 0	Alt + Ctrl + 0